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Rebound in NIH funds for Mass. researchers

Court wins limit decline, but scientists still wary

By Jonathan Saltzman
GLOBE STAFF

Massachusetts research labs recovered most of the federal funding that the Trump administration slashed early last year but still ended 2025 with slightly less than they received in 2024, according to a new analysis.

Scientists here faced a shortfall of \$500 million in July after the National Institutes of Health abruptly terminated millions of dollars in awards nationwide, the Massachusetts Biotechnology Council said. In making the cuts, the NIH targeted areas it said weren't in line with the administration's priorities, including research related to COVID, vaccine hesitancy, diversity, equity, and inclusion, transgender issues, and other topics.

But after the NIH settled a number of high-profile lawsuits brought by researchers and multiple states, scientists in Massachusetts ended the year with \$3.41 billion in funding. That represented a 1.4 percent decline, or just \$48 million less than in 2024, a far smaller reduction than many in the state's scientific ecosystem had feared.

"NIH funding rebounded beginning in September, following successful court challenges and policy changes, though its future remains uncertain, especially in research hubs like Massachusetts," said a new report by MassBio, a trade group for the state's biotechnology industry.

FUNDING, Page A6

Driver to use insanity defense in fatal crash

But that legal tactic can run a complicated course

By Lea Skene
GLOBE STAFF

The lawyer for the man accused of intentionally killing a prominent Boston art collector with his car last week confirmed he plans to mount an insanity defense, raising a complicated legal strategy that has repeatedly come under the spotlight in recent years.

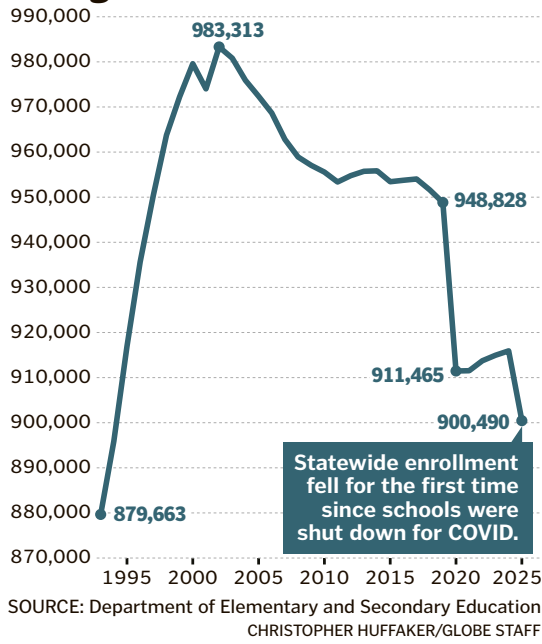
The defendant, William Haney Jr., has a long history of mental health struggles, which will certainly play a central role in the legal arguments, attorney Keith Halpern told the Globe in an interview.

Questions of criminal responsibility present unique challenges for both prosecutors and defense attorneys, experts say. In a ruling earlier this week, the state Supreme Judicial Court rejected an insanity defense brought by a man who killed his girlfriend in 2011, when they were teenagers, even though he was mentally ill at the time.

In Haney's case, prosecutors say the attack was deliberate. John Axelrod, 79, was walking his dog last Saturday morning when Haney drove onto the Commonwealth Avenue Mall and killed them both, according to prosecutors. The shocking attack left the Back Bay commu-

DEFENSE, Page A5

Falling numbers



Enrollment slips in state's public schools

Total hits 30-year low in a time marked by immigration crackdown

By Christopher Huffaker
GLOBE STAFF

Massachusetts public schools lost more than 15,000 students from 2024 to 2025, bringing overall enrollment to its lowest level in 30 years, according to the official Oct. 1 student counts released by the state Thursday.

Many of the state's largest districts and centers of immigrant populations saw particularly large declines, amid the impact of President Trump's immigration crackdown in the state.

Boston Public Schools resumed its long-term enrollment decline, after the district had

gained students in 2024 for the first time in a decade, when officials attributed the increase to new immigrant students. The drop of 1,645 students in Boston accounted for more than one of 10 students lost statewide.

The state's next eight largest districts, including Worcester and Springfield, also lost students.

The largest district to gain **ENROLLMENT, Page A10**



PHOTOS BY DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

IT'S
OFFICIAL,
THEY
ARE
READY
TO SERVE



Top, Jabulani D. Lindsay with his son, Kenzo, 2; daughter, Janiyah, 5; and sister Tamauya Lindsay, as Police Commissioner Michael A. Cox looked on at the graduation ceremony Friday for the Boston Police Department Recruit Class 66-25. Left, a cheering squad celebrated graduate Alena Curtis at the ceremony held in Dorchester.

After public dispute, a public apology

By Brooke Hauser
GLOBE STAFF

NORTHAMPTON — Bill Scher is no stranger to impassioned political discourse. He's a well-known political pundit who also happens to be married to the mayor of Northampton, Gina-Louise Sciarra.

But at the Stop & Shop on Wednesday, he picked an argument with a School Committee member,

Michael Stein, who has been an outspoken critic of his wife's reluctance to dip into the city's reserves to pay for the school budget.

And in a moment that speaks to the vituperative tone of American politics right now, Scher experienced a lapse of judgment he now calls "a cautionary tale for others to avoid."

In short, he started yelling, right there in the supermarket. An un-

nerved bystander summoned a store employee to intervene.

Soon, posts about the altercation had spread on social media, with one former city councilor sharing a Facebook video of herself disguised as a talking toilet-paper roll to bring attention to Scher's "unhinged behavior."

By Thursday evening, Scher had **NORTHAMPTON, Page A7**

Bears, such as this one in an undated photo, can be drawn to the easy meals they find in backyard bird feeders.



BILL BYRNE/MASS WILDLIFE

Why sleep through the winter when food's just hanging there?

Bird feeders blamed for off-season bear activity

By Brooke Hauser
GLOBE STAFF

Amherst resident Josh Rose thinks he is smarter than your average bear.

After black bears kept getting to his bird feeders, he devised a little experiment involving suet cakes made of rendered beef fat.

"I put out a mixture of hot-pepper and regular suet cakes," he said, "and a few days later found my feeders were all pulled down. The regular suet cakes were gone — in fact the entire feeders were gone — but the hot-pepper suet cakes were just lying on the ground, uneaten."

In short, he found a spicy solution to his

bear problem. But, added Rose, vice president of the Hampshire Bird Club, "I do know a guy up in the Berkshires who says that a bear comes to his yard and will even eat the hot-pepper suet cakes."

Welcome to Western Massachusetts, where for every success story about humans peacefully coexisting with black bears, there's also one that begins along the lines of, "I know a guy ..." and ends with a victorious bear.

Conventional wisdom is that hungry bears don't become a problem until March, when they emerge from their dens. But bears' habits are changing, and bird feeders are largely

BEARS, Page A10



Puddle pushers

Saturday: Cloudy, rainy. High: 43-48. Low: 36-41.

Sunday: Rain and drizzle. High: 42-47. Low: 25-30

Comics and Weather, **D4-5.**
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